The Care Arrangement Cheat Sheet

Eighteen plain words for the work of caring, and what to write down for each.

A family that shares someone's care ends up needing a handful of words for it, and mostly makes do without them. Here are eighteen, each in a plain line or two, with what to write down when it comes up. Where a definition comes from a public source it is marked. The rest are the Family Care Roadmap's own working words for this step.

The words are for talking about the arrangement clearly. They aren't for grading it.

The people

Caregiver

Someone who gives care to a person who needs help taking care of themselves. Informal caregivers are usually family members or friends; other caregivers are paid professionals. [1]

WRITE DOWN Everyone who does anything for your husband, and what each one does.

Primary caregiver

The person who takes on most of the everyday caregiving responsibilities. It tends to be a spouse, or the child or sibling who lives closest. [2]

WRITE DOWN Who that is in your family, and whether anyone has ever said so out loud.

Outside facilitator

A neutral person a family can invite to a meeting when it has trouble working together or is divided on a big issue. Social workers, ministers and physicians are among the people who can do this or refer you to someone who can. [3]

WRITE DOWN Whether the family would want one, and who it might be.

The work

Personal care

Dressing, bathing, grooming, using the toilet and brushing teeth. [4]

WRITE DOWN Who helps with any of these now, and how often.

Household tasks

Shopping, laundry and cleaning. Preparing food has its own line on the National Institute on Aging's list, and so does transportation, such as car rides to appointments. [4]

WRITE DOWN Who does each one now, and who drives.

Health care tasks

Talking to doctors, coordinating medical appointments and keeping track of medications. [4]

WRITE DOWN Who makes the calls, who goes along, and who keeps the medication list.

Paperwork

Paying bills and organizing important documents. [4]

WRITE DOWN Who handles it now, and where the papers are kept.

Workload

Everything it takes in a typical week to look after him, including the things that don't feel like care.

WRITE DOWN Each task, how often, roughly how long, and whether it's new or changed in the last year.

Hidden workload

The part of the work the rest of the family doesn't see. Writing about siblings who share a parent's care, the Family Caregiver Alliance says the others may assume the main caregiver has everything covered, so they don't recognize the added responsibilities. [5]

WRITE DOWN The tasks nobody else knows you do.

The words for a concern

Concern

Something about how the care is going that is on someone's mind, in that person's own words.

WRITE DOWN The words as they were said, and whose they are.

Observation, as against interpretation

An observation is what somebody saw or heard. An interpretation is what they think it means. “The refill was picked up three days late” is the first kind; “nobody pays attention to his pills” is the second.

WRITE DOWN What happened, when, and who saw it. Leave the meaning off the page.

Kind of concern

The roadmap sorts a concern by what it involves: care, communication, paperwork or workload.

WRITE DOWN Which of the four, beside each concern.

Unkept commitment

Something a person said they would do that hasn't happened. The words describe a task and not a person; the Family Caregiver Alliance's advice is to focus just on the issue at hand. [5]

WRITE DOWN The task and the date, with no adjectives.

Differing accounts

Two people describing the same thing differently. The Family Caregiver Alliance says differences in how family members see a situation are common. [5]

WRITE DOWN Both accounts, side by side, with whose each one is. No winner.

Open-issues list

A running list of concerns that aren't settled yet. The Family Caregiver Alliance says it will probably be difficult to cover every issue in one family meeting. [3]

WRITE DOWN Each open issue, and when it will next be talked about.

The conversation

Family meeting

A planned conversation among everyone who is part of the care, including the person receiving it. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests an agenda sent ahead of time and a narrow focus, and the National Institute on Aging says it is most productive when there is not an emergency. [3] [2]

WRITE DOWN A date, who is coming, and the one subject.

“I” message

A way of asking that starts from yourself: “I need,” rather than “You should.” [3]

WRITE DOWN Your opening line, starting with “I.”

Caregiving notebook

A notebook with details about the person's medical care, contact numbers and other pertinent details, kept where everyone involved has access to it and updated as needed. [2]

WRITE DOWN Whether one exists, where it is, and who keeps it up to date.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't say which of them describe your family, whether the arrangement is working, or whether your husband needs more help. That takes people who can look at the whole picture.

Ready for the next step?

You have the words, and something to note under each. The care interview uses the same plain language: it walks you through your husband's needs and the help around him one area at a time, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregiver Health
2. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
4. National Institute on Aging, Getting Started With Caregiving
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.